was afraid for *me*. He was holding on to my hand tightly and screaming, ‘Are you stupid? Why didn’t you run? Didn’t you hear the missile coming?’

How would I have known it was a missile? It was the first time I had experienced something like this. In that moment I realized the uncertainty of life during war.

Since the airstrip at Kargil was out of the direct line of sight of any of the Pakistani-occupied bunkers, they could only target it by listening to the sounds of the aircraft landing and taking off. Their intent was to cause damage to the aircraft and wreak havoc among the Indian ranks. Before the Pakistanis could target our helicopter again, my captain and I rushed to it and took off in a hurry. The Pakistani troops attempted such shelling in the future as well—but without success.

This incident wasn’t the end of such experiences for me. When flying close to the LoC, we were always briefed on which route to take and which of the enemy bunkers could attack us with shoulder-fired missiles. To counter the possibility of an attack, we had two options in front of us. We could either fly using the cover of the ridgeline or maintain an elevation of more than 5000 feet. I would take the second option, since a recce sortie required observation in the enemy area, and it wasn’t possible while flying using cover. After one such sortie, the captain of my helicopter and I were called by the COO to his office. It had to be something of concern, since the COO wouldn’t just call junior officers without reason. We wondered if we had done something wrong. When we were waiting outside his office, the COO’s runner told us he had called me inside first.

‘May I come in, Sir?’ I asked as I saluted him. Sitting behind a big walnut-wood table in his camouflage uniform, he gestured to me to come inside.

‘Yes, you, young lady,’ he said in his heavy, commanding voice. ‘Do you know where you flew today?’

‘Yes, Sir,’ I said. ‘We flew over the Dras sector and came back.’

‘Can you mark the route on the map and tell me?’ he said, looking at me with his index finger pointing at a blow-up of the Dras–Kargil sector map that hung on the wall behind his chair.